

What kind of posture is the phenomenological one? What kind of perspective does it assume?

Last time we introduced the core concept of phenomenology, a way to observe and describe phenomena not for what they are, but for how they appear to us.

When we say that a phenomenon appears it means two different things at the same time:

1. Appearing is intended as "showing itself to someone", who then will speak about it. Facts cannot tell themselves autonomously, so they need someone. That someone will be the observer.
2. The other meaning of appearing is "seeming". When something appears, it may be something else from it actually appears.
For example, when a single drop of rain falls, it's not enough to say it's raining. When multiple drops appear, then we can talk about the phenomena of "rain".

Consider now the internet and the web in 1966, when everything started, with an exchange of an email. With just one email exchanged, we cannot talk about the concept of Internet, it was just an appearance.

So, we can infer that for a phenomena to truly be such it must have qualitative and quantitative consistency. Qualitative because the phenomena must show itself through certain qualities, and quantitative as it must do so with a certain intensity over a duration of time. It must also unfold its effect over time (not a single rain drop, not a single email).

Phenomenology is a way of observing things that is consciously limited, taking in account the possibility of being fennible. It does not aim to tell us what a thing is, but how it appears to us.

This is a posture that is different and humbler than the science's one, who's task is to reveal what entities are. Phenomenology always takes into account that the person who describes the phenomena is a person, therefore having a partial and conditioned vision because of its purpose/goal, so that's not a neutral observer, as there are no neutral facts, only interpretation. A fact cannot tell itself, but needs someone to interpret it. In order to describe a phenomena, speaking about it is not enough to look at it. There must be a subject capable of understanding it, and somehow remanage this experience in the form of word, "logos".

Let's dive deeper in this term. It's a term with a broad semantic field (a complex of meanings that pertain to a word). It can be intended as "thought", "word", "line of reasoning", "an idea", "a study", "a discipline". What element unites all these

meanings?

The most important meanings are given by three concepts contained into "logos", that are not distant from each other:

- thinking
- word
- God

What is thinking? We can say that's an inner discourse that always takes the form of words. What is a word? Words are the tangible manifestation of thoughts, of study, culture, heritage, family, etc.

In the Christian religion, logos is God.

It's evident that every observer who approaches a phenomenon will produce a different interpretation of it. Example: If a fire breaks into a forest, and we ask to different witnesses each person will report a different fact. Examples of persons could be a fire fighter, a lumberjack, a poet. Each of them will describe the same phenomenon, but seen from different perspectives. Are all these perspectives valid? Each one it's valid in its own way. No one is more true than others. The use of different tools change the interpretation.

Hermeneutics seeks to examine these interpretations, and attempt to explain them.

What is the main job of an interpreter? It's to explain, coming from "explanare", which means "make plane".

In this way, we try to reach the true interpretation, the right and correct one.

However, another problem arrives. Who tells us which interpretation is the real one?

Let's make another example: Peot. There is a part of ?, that says that we have to live the fruit of the field, thus when we cut the harvest of our land, we don't cut the corner. Why? Because we can live this nutrishment for the poor, and for the people, so that they don't need to beg to survive. The interpreter, however, had preferred to understand this commandments, as to not cut the corners of our hair (?).

Let's think about the act of interpretation as organised between two pillars: truth and freedom. A state, a nation, is said to be democratic or totalitarian depending on which of these two possibilities is allowed or encouraged to emerged and prevail. A democratic state will be more interested in truth or in freedom?

According to classmates, the answer is freedom.

If a State wants to state the truth, it means that it doesn't care about freedom,

rather about power. Democracy, instead, it's a chorus, that will gather voices together, forming the truth.

Today, who is the holder of the truth? It's science. The scientific paradigm is currently considered not to be just an interpretation, but a law that is the only valid parameter of reliability and rational decision making. Science is the only one that can say some-thing. Let's take a closer look at this statement. Even when we ask ourselves what "some-thing" is, it starts to sound clear that we primarily understand what surrounds us as a thing. Let's consider the word "re-ality". It comes from "res" (in latin, it means "thing"). What does this situation reveal about science, that tends to consider entities simply as things. Let's think about the word entity, it's something that "is being" ("sta essendo"), that is alive. Where does this current dominance of science over every other form of knowledge come from? It's the dominance of instrumental thinking (directs it's inquiries towards objectives and purposes) over contemplative thinking (typical of poetry, sacred texts). Specifically, contemplative comes from "cum-templum", with templum coming from "tempus" (time). What is a temple? It's not only a sacred space, but also a sacred time. Whoever enters a temple, also enters a time whose rhythm is different from the rhythm we encounter outside. It's a place where one does not do anything, and he just is. There is no place for productivity here. Contemplation sees things, but does not wish to possess them. This form simply lets things being as they are, without forcing them in a specific direction. Contemplation does not wish to become an instrument, but simply be there. Nowadays, there's less time to abandon ourselves to the experience of contemplation, as time needs to be optimised by forcing it in scientific experiments. There is a difference between experience and experiments. An experience is something broader than an experiment, as it has no purpose that is pre-inserted. The experiment, differently, sees everything as sterile, taking from repetitions a law out of it.

Science looks at reality as some-thing to be known, and then used for the human purposes. Science, for example, says "Water is ". The question is, what is "is" in the definition? When science is asked what is "being", it struggles.

Heidegger says that what is closest to us, it's often what remains more obscure. It's something that we grasp, but vaguely. Science uses the word "to be", but they rely on something they don't have.

Heidegger notes that over time, "being" has become (?).

The idea of "being" equals reality, that is convincing for Science, did not persuade Heidegger, who reflected on the question of being, which is the "seins frage", with seins meaning "be", while "frage" is the "question".

Let's introduce Heidegger. He was German, born in 1889, in a rural village in the southern-eastern part of Germany. He addressed very large philosophical questions, and did not travel a lot. Typically, he moved in a triangle of cities. In one of them, he built a hut and spent a lot of time in isolation, completing his masterpiece.

If we don't consider travelling just not as a geographical movement, but rather as a change of perspective, then his most significant journey is the one in which he was young, and accompanied his father to the "campanile" every day.

For Heidegger, time was not just an abstraction or a theoretical construct, rather something concrete and powerful. Heidegger experienced time not only acoustically, but also visually, from the elevated perspective of the bell tower, where every day, at the same hour, he could see the world reappearing, always the same, but always different at the same time.

The Church financed his education, and although he was a good student, he was also a country boy, who found himself studying alongside influential families.

However, he distanced himself from social circles, and dedicated himself to study. Soon, his intellectual honesty pushed him to continue his studies, but through his own resources. He stated that his research was not theological, but ontological. For a theoretical research, we need to accept a dogma. What does ontological mean? It means something that concerns "being". It derives from *ὄντως*, and "logos". Ontology is the discourse of study around beings. We need to make clear a difference between ontological and ontic, that refers to entities and things that exists, while ontology refers to the being of those things.

Science is referred to ontic studies, while philosophy to ontological studies.

We must also underline that Heidegger was not a white fly addressing these questions. Thinkers like Kierkegaard, and Nietzsche, already did.

Although, he became one of the most important representative of existentialism. It's a philosophical current with a focus on being, existence.

Before the military application, technology had appeared in the industrial form, promising wealth, richness, development. It was the time when Ford, Fiat were founded, and new big industries were emerging and developing. The assembly line was invented, and the total organisation of society was beginning to form.

It was also the age of mass political ideologies and parties.

The individual was compressed into roles, functions, with the aim of efficiency. People began to reflect on existential questions, like freedom, and their human condition.

Heidegger begins his research from the ones who question being. The ones who questions being, is part of general being, but unlike the other entities that are

simply present, human beings asks/wonder/research about their being. We're the only creature asking questions, and this happens as we're not happy with what we have.

For this reason, we are called the "existent", coming from "ek-sistere", where "sistere" means to stay, while "ek" means "out". Human beings stays out of the single presence in the world, as it seeks meaning. Meaning, with latin origin "sensus".

Other living beings seem not to need to find new paths beyond the existence path, they don't feel injustice, problems, complications.

Thus, remember that "seins" means being. Heidegger then calls the human being "dasein", which has as a meaning "to be here" ("esserci"). Basically it means that being here is being conscious of being, but also being aware of the possibility of no longer being here, so human beings are aware of their mortality.

Heidegger approaches the question of being, starting from the "dasein", the entity raising the question of being. The question is not about who "dasein" is, but how it is, how "dasein" presents itself (for phenomenology).

There are some characteristics of "dasein" that Heidegger calls existential.